VAlanthropy Newsletter & Donation Popup Build Plan

Oct 26, 2026 · @Nate

Phase 0: Access and discovery

Answer these in the first two days, before writing code:

- [ ] Get a WordPress admin (or editor + plugin install) account, and confirm who hosts the site
- [ ] Ask the org to set up a local or staging copy of the site (e.g., LocalWP export) so you never test on the live site
- [ ] Confirm the NFG plan the org already pays for includes email marketing and API access (no upgrades), and get API credentials or docs
- [ ] In NFG, check whether donation pages allow a custom "redirect after donation" URL
- [ ] Ask whether donors can choose to give anonymously, and what the org is comfortable displaying (first name? city? amount?)
- [ ] Check which page builder the site uses (Elementor, Gutenberg, etc.) so popups and forms match its tooling
- [ ] Note the brand colors and fonts from the site so new UI matches

Phase 1: Newsletter

Send the newsletter from NFG's built-in email so subscribers and donors stay in one database; your work is mostly on the website side.

Stack: NFG email marketing · NFG signup form · WordPress (Elementor or Gutenberg block) · a little CSS/JS for the modal.

1. Collect requirements: cadence (monthly is typical), who writes content, what goes in each issue (construction progress, veteran stories, donation asks).
2. Rebuild the signup experience on the site:
   - Replace the off-site "Sign up for updates" link with an embedded NFG form, if NFG offers embed code; otherwise style a button that opens it in a modal.
   - Add a signup block to the footer and to the end of each News & Stories post.

    - Optional: an exit-intent or scroll-triggered signup popup (show once per visitor, easy to close), hand-coded or with the free version of Popup Maker.
3. Build a reusable email template in NFG: logo, brand colors, a progress-update block, a story block, one clear Donate button, and the required footer (unsubscribe link + P.O. Box mailing address).
4. Set up segments: all subscribers vs. donors, so donors can get thank-you and impact updates.
5. Send test emails to Gmail, Outlook and a phone; check links, images and dark mode.
6. Hand off: a short how-to doc so staff can send future issues without you.

If NFG email isn't on their plan: use a free tier instead: MailPoet's free plan (sends from WordPress, capped subscribers and monthly sends), Brevo free (caps daily sends, not contacts) or Mailchimp free. Move contacts between NFG and the email tool with CSV export/import, which costs nothing.

Phase 2: Thank-you popup

When a donor finishes on NFG, send them back to the site and greet them with a thank-you modal; this needs no API.

Stack: NFG redirect setting · a small WordPress plugin or code-snippet (vanilla JS + CSS) · optional confetti library.

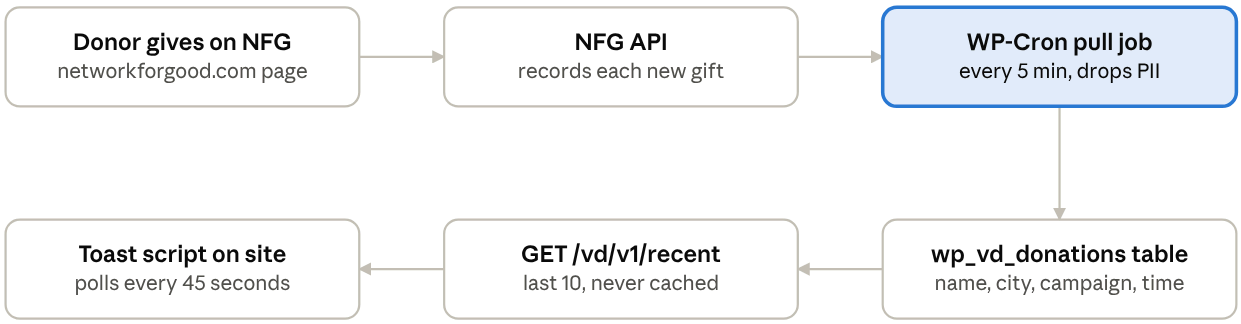
1. In NFG, set each donation page's post-gift redirect to something like `https://valanthropy.org/?thanks=1`.
2. Write a small script that checks `URLSearchParams` for `thanks`, shows a modal, then removes the parameter with `history.replaceState` so a refresh doesn't re-trigger it.
3. Modal content: a short thank-you, a progress photo of Hidden Wounds Village Alpha, and two buttons — "Join the newsletter" and "Share on Facebook."
4. Make it accessible: focus moves into the modal, Esc and the X close it, and it respects reduced-motion settings.
5. Exclude the page from WP Rocket's cache only if needed (the script runs client-side, so it usually works with caching).

If NFG has no redirect option: link to a dedicated `/thank-you` page from NFG's confirmation email or receipt instead.

Phase 3: Live "someone just donated" popups

A scheduled job on WordPress pulls new donations from NFG's API every few minutes and stores a minimal record; a small script on every page checks for new ones and shows a toast. No third-party automation service, no paid plugin.

A free cron job is the only bridge from NFG to the site



donation feed · Path B data flow

The highlighted cron job is the piece you build; it keeps the NFG API key on the server, and everything downstream only ever sees a first name, city and time.

Pick one path after Phase 0:

Path	Stack (all free)	Effort	Best when
A. Redirect counter (fallback)	NFG redirect → `?thanks=1` → WP REST endpoint logs "a gift happened" → toast says "Someone just gave"	2–3 days	NFG plan has no API access
B. WordPress cron pull (recommended)	WP-Cron + cron-job.org → NFG API → custom DB table → WP REST endpoint → vanilla JS toast	~1.5 weeks	NFG API is available; you want everything in one plugin
C. Free serverless	Cloudflare Workers free plan with a cron trigger → NFG API → Workers KV → JS snippet on WordPress	~1.5 weeks	You'd rather not write PHP; you're fine depending on a free-tier account

Path A can't confirm a gift really happened (anyone can open the `?thanks=1` link), so use it only with the org's sign-off and prefer a weekly count ("12 gifts this week") over individual toasts.

Build steps for Path B:

1. **Confirm the data source.** Get NFG API credentials and docs from the org. Pull a sample donation with Postman or curl and note the fields (first name, city, campaign, anonymous flag, timestamp).
2. **Scaffold the plugin.** `valanthropy-donation-feed/` in a free GitHub repo, with an activation hook that creates a `wp_vd_donations` table (id, nfg_id, display_name, city, campaign, created_at).
3. **Pull.** Register a WP-Cron event on a 5-minute custom interval that calls the NFG API with `wp_remote_get` for gifts newer than the last-seen ID (saved in `wp_options`). Keep the API key in a `wp-config.php` constant. Drop anonymous names, keep no email, amount or address.
4. **Make cron reliable.** WP-Cron only runs when someone visits the site, so add a free cron-job.org job that hits `wp-cron.php` every 5 minutes.
5. **Serve.** Register `GET /wp-json/vd/v1/recent?since=<timestamp>` returning the last 10 donations from the past 7 days.
6. **Display.** Enqueue a small JS file that polls `/recent` every 45 seconds, queues new items, and shows one toast at a time for ~6 seconds ("Sarah from Sumter just helped build veteran housing"), linking to the Donate page.
7. **Settings page.** WP admin toggles: on/off, show city yes/no, pages to exclude, max popups per visit.
8. **Cache safety.** Make sure WP Rocket doesn't cache the `/recent` response (send `Cache-Control: no-store`).
9. **Test** with mocked API responses on staging, then one real test donation with the org.

Testing, privacy and launch

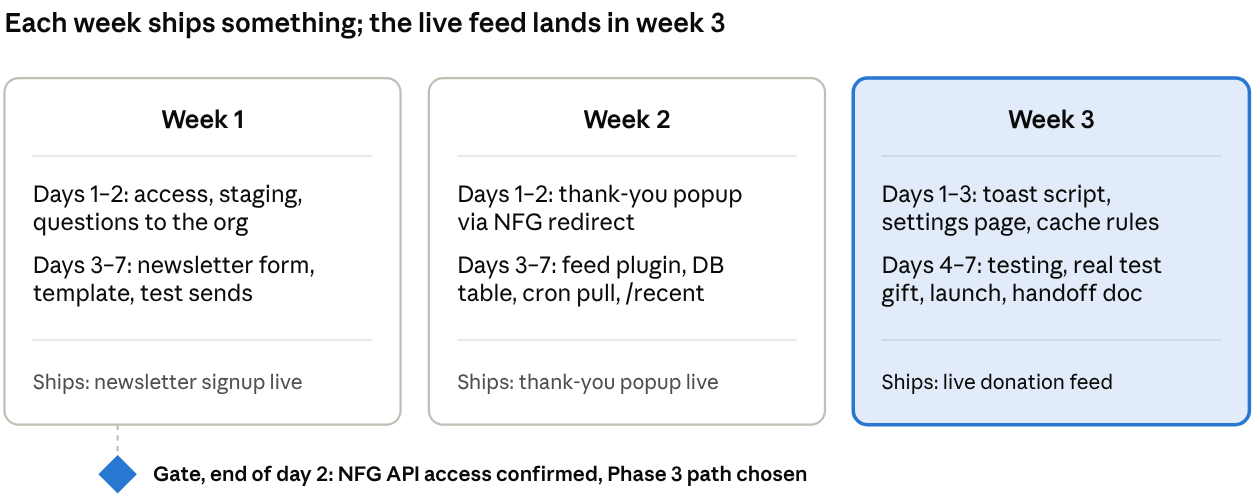
The org's credibility with donors matters more than any feature, so nothing goes live without these.

- [ ] Everything built and tested on staging first, then deployed to the live site
- [ ] NFG API key lives in wp-config.php, never in the browser, the repo or the database

- [ ] Only real donations are shown; no placeholder or recycled entries ever reach the live site
- [ ] Anonymous donors show as "Someone"; names and amounts only with the org's written OK
- [ ] No emails, full names, addresses or payment details are stored or sent to the browser
- [ ] Popups don't cover the Donate buttons on mobile and can be closed with one tap
- [ ] Lighthouse score checked before and after, so the popup doesn't slow the site
- [ ] Newsletter footer has unsubscribe link and mailing address (CAN-SPAM)
- [ ] Short handoff doc: how to send an issue, turn popups off, and rotate the NFG API key

Timeline and open questions

Three weeks, which assumes roughly 10–12 hours a week; Phase 3's path is decided by day 2, once NFG access is known.



build roadmap · 3 weeks